To the Ends of the Earth

Acts 3–12

The big idea: Arrests, beatings, and the death of Stephen could not stop the church. Persecution scattered the believers, and they preached wherever they went: to Samaria, to an Ethiopian official, and to a Roman soldier's household. Salvation is in Christ alone, and God shows no partiality.

Before you meet: Read

Acts 4:1–20 | Acts 7:54–8:4 | Acts 10:34–48

Open (5 minutes)

Have you ever had to stand up for something unpopular? What gave you courage?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"And there is _____ in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved." *(Acts 4:12)*

"We must obey _____ rather than men." *(Acts 5:29)*

"Truly I understand that God shows no _____." *(Acts 10:34)*

Discuss

1. Persecution scattered the believers, and they preached wherever they went. Have you seen hardship spread the gospel? *Acts 8:1–4*

2. Peter had to learn that God shows no partiality. What barriers between people does the gospel break down today? *Acts 10:28, 34–35; Ephesians 2:19–22*

3. As he died, Stephen prayed, "Lord, do not hold this sin against them." Where do you need grace to pray like that? *Acts 7:59–60*

Memory verse

"But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."

Acts 1:8

Pray

Ask God for courage to speak of Jesus this week. Pray for believers who are suffering for him today, and for one person you know who feels far from God.

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Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Acts 4:8–20 and 10:34–48 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Acts 9:1–31, 13–14, and 16–17).

Main points to land

1. Salvation is in Christ alone, and persecution cannot stop his word; it spreads it (Acts 4:12; 8:4; 12:24).
2. The gospel crosses every barrier, from Jerusalem to Samaria to the Gentiles, fulfilling the promise to Abraham (Acts 1:8; 10:34; 11:18; Genesis 12:3).
3. Stephen died like his Lord, praying for the men who killed him (Acts 7:59–60).

Answer key (Observe)

1. salvation
2. God
3. partiality

Questions people will ask

Why did Saul persecute the church, and how could God use him?
Saul believed Jesus was a false Messiah and that the church was a threat to God's law (Philippians 3:6). The risen Jesus met him on the road and changed him (Acts 9:1–6). Paul later called himself the foremost of sinners, saved as an example of Christ's patience (1 Timothy 1:15–16).

Closing prayer

Lord Jesus, there is salvation in no one else. Give us the courage of Peter and John and the forgiving heart of Stephen. Carry your word through us to the people around us, near and far, until it reaches the end of the earth. Amen.